

Lead Lifecycle

This doc outlines how we track where each lead and contact is in the sales engagement process, from first touch through closed deal.

Overview

What it does: The Lead Lifecycle system tracks the current engagement status of every lead and contact, enabling Sales and Marketing to engage with the right people at the right time.

Why it matters: By understanding where each individual is in the buying process, we can:

- Prioritize outreach to the right leads
- Avoid over-contacting people already in active conversations
- Identify leads that need re-engagement
- Measure conversion rates between stages

Two status dimensions: We track leads across two parallel dimensions:

Field	What It Tracks	Updated By
Lead/Contact Status	Sales engagement stage	Salesloft, Marketo, SFDC automation, manual
Marketing Status	Marketing engagement level	Marketo (based on lead score)

For this document, "lead" and "contact" are used interchangeably.

Lead/Contact Status (Sales Engagement)

Lead/Contact Status reflects the current state of **Sales engagement** with an individual. This is the primary lifecycle field used for routing, reporting, and segmentation.

Status Flow

[View full diagram in Lucid Chart](#)

Status Definitions

Status	Definition	Entrance Criteria	Exit Criteria
Open	All new leads enter here	New lead created	Any action that changes status
Attempting Contact	SDR/AE has added lead to cadence or sent email	Cadence started or activity logged	→ Engaging (reply received) · → Nurture (no reply in 14 days) · → No Potential

Engaging	Reply has been logged against this contact	Reply logged (cadence or not)	→ Qualifying (Disc Call created) · → Nurture (no Disc Call in 30 days) · → No Potential
Qualifying	Discovery Call created in person's name	Disc Call created	→ Selling (Opp created) · → Nurture (no contact 30 days, no scheduled call) · → No Potential
Selling	Contact is on an open opportunity	Opp created with person as primary contact	→ Sold (Opp Won) · → Nurture (Opp Lost) · → No Potential
Sold	Contact was primary on a won opportunity	Opp marked Closed Won	Any action that changes status (treated like Open)
Nurture	Contacted before but didn't reach Sold	Exited from any working status	Any action that changes status (treated like Open)

No Potential	Should not be contacted (bad persona or data)	Manual flag or invalid email	Email changed, manual removal, or Sales starts outreach
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Note: "Nurture" status does not guarantee the lead will be added to lifecycle programs—it simply indicates they were previously contacted but are not currently in an active sales motion.

Nurture Reasons

When a lead moves to Nurture status, a reason is required:

Reason	Definition
No Contact	Contact was attempted but unsuccessful. Auto-set if in "Attempting Contact" too long.
Went Cold	Successful contact occurred but conversation went cold
Low Interest	Contact made but not currently interested
Timing	Contact made but not the right time

No Potential Reasons

When a lead is marked No Potential, a reason is required:

Reason	Definition
Left Company	Individual no longer at the company. SDRs should check if they moved and create new record.
Vendor / Competitor	Not a target—never include in emails
No Use Case	Not a target, but may receive marketing emails if they engage
Benchling Applicant	Applied for or expressed interest in a job
Academic	Works at a university or is a student
Deletion Request	Formally requested data removal
Bad Data	Contact info incorrect but may be real person

Bounced	Email bounced (same as Bad Data, specifically from bounce)
Junk	Clearly spam or invalid data

Note: Nurture Reasons and No Potential Reasons share the same field in SFDC (Status Detail).

Note on Bounced: "Bounced" exists as both a top-level status and a No Potential reason due to tool limitations. When a lead is set to "Bounced" at the top level, automation converts it to "No Potential" with reason "Bad Data."

Note on Conversion Statuses: The following statuses exist for SFDC lead-to-contact conversion operations only and are not part of the standard lifecycle flow:

- **Re-Open** — Lead converted to contact, no opportunity
- **Converted with Opp** — Lead converted with an associated opportunity
- **Converted no Opp** — Lead converted without an opportunity

These are set automatically during conversion and typically transition to a standard status (Open, Selling) shortly after.

Marketing Status (Marketing Engagement)

Marketing Status tracks the **engagement level** with marketing campaigns and content. This is entirely automated based on lead score.

Status	Definition
Cold	Below half of the MQL threshold
Warm	At or above half of the MQL threshold
Hot	At or above the MQL threshold
Non-Target	Contact Status = No Potential

Automatic updates:

- When demographic or behavior score changes, Marketing Status updates accordingly
- When Contact Status changes to No Potential, Marketing Status becomes "Non-Target"
- When email address changes or successful email sent to "Bad Data" status, lead moves to Open/Cold

Link to: <https://benchling.atlassian.net/wiki/spaces/Marketing/pages/1734476158>

for full scoring model and MQL thresholds

Status Transitions

Automatic Transitions

The following transitions happen automatically via Marketo/Salesloft/SFDC automation:

Trigger	From Status	To Status	Detail
Sales email logged	Open, Nurture, Sold, No Potential	Attempting Contact	Null
Reply logged	Any working status	Engaging	Null
Disc Call created	Any status	Qualifying	Null
Opportunity created	Any status	Selling	Null
Opportunity Won	Selling	Sold	Null
Opportunity Lost	Selling	Nurture	Timing
Email bounced	Any (except Sold)	No Potential	Bad Data

No reply in 14 days	Attempting Contact	Nurture	No Contact
No activity in 30 days	Engaging	Nurture	Went Cold
No contact in 30 days, no scheduled call	Qualifying	Nurture	No Contact
Email address changed	No Potential (Bad Data)	Open	Null
Successful email to Bad Data	No Potential	Open or Attempting Contact	Null

Manual Transitions

Some transitions require manual action:

- Marking a lead as No Potential (with reason)
- Removing a lead from No Potential
- Setting specific Nurture reasons (Low Interest, Timing)

Relationship to Other Systems

MQL and Lead Routing

When a lead becomes an MQL, the Lead/Contact Status does not automatically change. MQL is a separate qualification event that triggers routing. A lead can be:

- Status = Open + MQL = Yes (new lead who hand-raised)
- Status = Nurture + MQL = Yes (re-engaged lead who crossed threshold)
- Status = Qualifying + MQL = No (already in sales motion before MQL)

Link to: [LINK: Lead Routing] for routing rules and SLAs

MSL (Marketing Sourced Leads)

MSLs follow the same lifecycle but enter via event/webinar attendance rather than MQL. They're routed for awareness-building rather than immediate sales motion.

Technical Reference

Key Fields

Field	Object	Description
Lead Status / Contact Status	Lead, Contact	Current sales engagement status
Status Detail	Lead, Contact	Reason for Nurture or No Potential status

Marketing Status	Lead, Contact	Current marketing engagement level (Cold/Warm/Hot/Non-Target)
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History Tracking

All status fields have history tracking enabled for reporting on:

- Time in each status
- Conversion rates between statuses
- Status change velocity

Legacy Reference

For historical implementation details and automation logic, see: [Old Lead Lifecycle Implementation Notes](#)

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